
STOP
OVERFLOW

THE OVERFLOW

010 / 15 AUG 2010 / BITCOIN / RARE

WE NEED A FIX ASAP.

A lone engineer reaches for a red STOP button as a brass mint spills coins across the floor. The control panel flashes OVERFLOW. This imaginary workshop makes a software emergency visible: an exploited validation flaw, not an innocent factory accident or a theft of customer deposits.

On 15 August 2010, Jeff Garzik noticed something strange in Bitcoin block 74,638. A transaction exploiting a validation flaw had two outputs of more than 92 billion BTC each. Added together, their values overflowed the software's arithmetic check and slipped past a limit that should have rejected them. The result was roughly 184.47 billion invalid bitcoins in that branch of the chain.

The response was urgent and collective. A forum post called for a fix as soon as possible. Gavin Andresen offered an early patch, other participants examined the failure, and Satoshi worked on the correction. Version 0.3.10 patched the overflow bug that same day. The corrected chain overtook the bad branch; those impossible coins are not part of Bitcoin's accepted history.

The engineer is a fictional figure, not a portrait of a developer or the attacker. One person at a stop button compresses a collective response into a single moment; Bitcoin had no central emergency switch. The torrent represents invalid coin creation, not a legitimate increase in Bitcoin's supply. A conspicuous D-marked coin looks forward to Dogecoin, which did not yet exist.

DETAILS IN THE ART

01 THE STOP BUTTON

The engineer's outstretched hand reaches the large red button. It pictures the urgency of stopping the exploit, not a real Bitcoin control switch or a lone person repairing the network.

02 THE OVERFLOW WARNING

OVERFLOW glows red on the right-hand panel. The gauges and machinery turn a transaction-validation failure into a workshop alarm; they are fictional, not historical diagnostic equipment.

03 TOO MANY COINS

Bitcoin-marked coins pour down the chute and bury the floor. Their excess evokes roughly 184.47 billion invalid bitcoins, not physical minting or a change to Bitcoin's valid supply.

04 A COIN FROM THE FUTURE

A large D-marked coin sits among the Bitcoin coins near the engineer's knee. It is an intentional forward reference to Birth of Doge, not a historical currency or object in this 2010 scene.

SOURCE & ART NOTE

Jeff Garzik's original block report records block 74,638 and the enormous outputs. The emergency discussion, opened by lfm, contains “We need a fix asap” and the collaborative patch work. The caption capitalizes and punctuates that phrase. Satoshi's version 0.3.10 announcement records the patch and later reports the good chain overtaking the bad. Dogecoin's history dates its launch to December 2013. The engineer, mint, controls and physical coins are fictional; the D coin is a deliberate later-card crossover.